

the consumers thought. Two thirds were neutral, and one third were actually positive about being taught by Indians. These 25 were not Indian / Asian-origin US citizens: they were local US citizens. One of them said they would *never* let an Indian coach their kid on sports, but on education, he welcomed it!"

Old Way, Tech Way

Here in India, we're used to classrooms bursting at the hinges of the door—perhaps 120 or 150 students packed into a lecture hall. It's different in America, for a variety of reasons. Undergraduate classrooms typically host about 30, 40, or 50 students. Note that this is an average figure; the actual numbers vary wildly—from 15 to 150 by some accounts. At the graduate level, you might even see 10 or 15 students in a class. Or sometimes even five!

Then there's the T-word: practically all 10th and 12th-standard students here "go to tuition," as we say. There's a similar concept in the US—"learning centres." At typical learning centres, a few students congregate in a room with a teacher, computer, and projector, for lessons specifically geared towards improving grades. The key word here is "few," and that's why tutoring at learning centres is expensive.

One-on-one coaching is even more expensive. Make no mistake about it: grades are as important in the US as marks are here, even if the education system is vastly different. And like we mentioned, TutorVista makes one-on-one affordable. That is Ganesh's vision: "We want to make personalised education affordable, and that our service should be part of every home's monthly budget through a subscription based, 'always-on' kind of model."

The 1:1 ratio is the ideal, and it has always been. We don't need to explain why. As in so many areas, technology has been thrown at the problem, and one-on-one might one day become the norm instead of a luxury. TutorVista deserves mention even if only for making personalised coaching affordable to the majority of Americans.

But Ganesh goes a step further: he says Internet learning can be more effective than even face-to-face learning! It is appropriate here to also quote Roger Schank, director of the Institute for Learning Sciences at Northwestern University: "The best things technology has given training are the possibility of one-on-one for every learner, the ability to simulate, and the chance to try stuff out and fail in private without the fear of ridicule from other students."

I Say Tuh-Mah-Toe, You Say...

Banking call centre employees, as an example, are taught American and British accents partly to make it sound to the caller that he or she is speaking to a native English speaker, which makes him or her more comfortable. But when it comes to something more personal and more long-term like education, it's a more vital question—that of accent not interfering with the learning process.

TutorVista trains tutors not only with regards to accent, but also in communication



Internet learning can be more effective than face-to-face learning"

Krishnan Ganesh
Founder, chairman, and CEO
TutorVista

skills. Also, says Ganesh, the fact that the talk time by the tutor is only 20 per cent of the total session time makes it less of an issue. "Most of the time, the student is either thinking or writing on the whiteboard or speaking. Also, since the same tutor works with the student, student and tutor get used to (each other's) accents."

In addition, at the time of recruiting, TutorVista also ensures that the tutor's accent is good enough for him or her to be able to communicate with US and/or UK students.

Accent is a relatively small issue the company faced. Ganesh sums up some of the others thus: "We deliver real-time, live sessions to thousands of students and to thousands of tutors concurrently. Handling this requires a strong-scalable platform, which is unique. We had to build this from scratch. Also, being a consumer brand, we needed to establish an image in the minds of consumers, unlike other e-learning companies that work with the corporate customer rather than directly with consumers."

Now And Onward

In November 2006, TutorVista was named the exclusive online tutoring provider for Microsoft's MSN Encarta online education portal. The deal calls for MSN Encarta to actively market TutorVista's services throughout the Encarta portal.

Then, TutorVista offers *free* online tutoring sessions to public school students of all ages in America's top 10 poorest, most rural counties. "We opened TutorVista in the US because we saw school systems failing America's poorest rural students, teachers and parents on a number of levels," explains Ganesh.

How is the market for one-on-one tutoring poised to grow? Exponentially, according to Ganesh. But it "needs the right business model. We believe that subscription-based mass-market pricing will be the key for future growth." TutorVista also has plans to venture into the Australian, Canadian, and, yes, the Indian e-learning markets. They are also looking at launching an English-language service for Chinese and Korean students. With India getting to be known as an "educational hotbed," there's good reason to believe their new ventures will find acceptance.

We'll be keenly watching to see how one-on-one e-learning for school and college kids might work out in this country. TutorVista may have worked it all out for American and the other markets, but it's a little different here. Parents' perceptions, Internet bandwidth and connection performance, and very high cost sensitivity come to mind.

Still, marks will be marks; what ultimately matters is performance on paper. If the firm can work out how to boost students' exam performance given the ridiculous levels of competition here—with precision levels reaching one mark per 500 or more—it'll be one more success story. ■

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